

What else to watch: *The Jazz Singer* (1927, p.330) ■ *Top Hat* (1935) ■ *A Star Is Born* (1937) ■ *Anchors Aweigh* (1945) ■ *Ziegfeld Follies* (1945) ■ *On the Town* (1949) ■ *Sunset Boulevard* (1950, pp.114-15) ■ *An American in Paris* (1951)



change with the times. Unless he can learn to work with synchronized sound, Don is destined, in his words, to become “a museum piece.”

His position very much mirrors the status of the musical as a genre at the time that *Singin' in the Rain* was released: in 1952, it was a format whose heyday seemed to be passing. There is one memorable sequence when *The Dueling Cavalier*, a silent movie Don is

making with his shallow co-star, Lina Lamont (Jean Hagen), is being reshot for sound. The cast and crew are out of their depth with the new technology; for example, even the talented Don asks for dialogue to be replaced with him repeating “I love you,” unaware of how wooden that will sound in a “talkie.” The scene addresses his fears of replacement, as his skills and methodology become redundant, and the

In one of Don's (Gene Kelly's) flashback career moments, we see him becoming a big Broadway star and performing *Gotta Dance*.

mistakes he makes on account of that anxiety, but it is also about the eclipsing of the musical by other genres of movie.

The arc of creativity

One of the key themes of *Singin' in the Rain* is the undignified and humiliating work that creative people are willing to do in order to get ahead in the industry. This is highlighted in three stories within the movie. In the first, Don reminisces to a journalist on the red carpet at a premiere. As he waxes lyrical about his dignified rise to stardom, the »

“If we bring a little joy into your humdrum lives, it makes us feel as though our hard work ain't been in vain for nothin'.”

Lina Lamont / Singin' in the Rain